

magining the Ramayana through the perspective of Hanuman. It has been designed and directed by Kulvinder Bakshish Singh. Over the Dussehra week, the production will be premiered in Mumbai on October 18 before moving to Bengaluru.

Ray has previously directed the hit musical play *Ek Radha*. "Hanuman is a character who represents strength, devotion, humility and unwavering faith, and we want the audience to experience all of those dimensions," says Ray. "The production is ambitious in terms of its visual language, but we are equally focused on making it emotionally engaging."

Can theatre keep up with or outdo the spectacle promised by cinema? Adds Narayan, "There is no screen between the actor and the audience. There is no retake. If, then, the audience becomes emotional, or an entire auditorium seems to breathe together, that is an experience cinema can never quite replicate."

Immediacy makes actor Ankit Mohan's task of playing Hanuman doubly hard. He is joined by Arya Babbar as Ravan, Saanand Verma as Vistarvachie, Pankaj Berry as Kaal Drishti, along with Mukul Nag and Aadesh Bharadwaj, with Vaidika Senjaliya portraying Sita. "You need to be connected spiritually to the universal divine while playing God," says Mohan. "I was completely vegetarian during the role. When life tests and breaks you, you wonder why. But when good things happen, you seldom question it—this role has been a gift like that." ■

—Devarsi Ghosh

Mahabali *will be performed in Mumbai, at the NCPA* ***(Oct. 18)*** *and Nehru Centre* ***(Oct. 24)****, and at Phoenix Marketcity, Bengaluru* ***(Nov. 14)***

by Padam Singh and Hira Devi, is the soul of the film. "I told them you have to fight how you would with your partners," he says.

While Kapri was at ease in the topography, most of his crew from Kolkata embraced the challenge. "We'd trek for two hours to reach locations, cross forests; there was fear of leopard attacks," he says of the 14-hour shifts daily for a month. There are no villains in *Pyre*; instead Kapri is keen to show a place where development never reaches and information travels slow.

"One truth that can't be denied is death," he adds. "Let's make those last days beautiful." Kapri also hopes the film inspires young filmmakers from his homeland to tell their stories. ■

—Suhani Singh



GOING STRONG The Dharamshala International Film Festival took off in 2012

FESTIVAL ▼

MOVIES IN THE HILLS

THE 15TH DHARAMSHALA INTERNATIONAL FILM FESTIVAL PROMISES A MIX OF INDIAN AND INTERNATIONAL CINEMA

Ritu Sarin and Tenzing Sonam shun glorious proclamations. Talk to the co-founders of the Dharamshala International Film Festival (DIFF) as it prepares to complete 15 years this year, and they stress the improbability of it all. "We never thought we'd make it to this edition, considering all the challenges along the way," they smile. Like many things in life, DIFF emerged from absence. When filmmakers Sarin and Sonam moved to Dharamshala in 1996, the town lacked a contemporary cultural event. In 2012, in McLeod Ganj, a town without a cinema hall, they decided to build one for their community.

The 15th-anniversary edition arrives with several Indian premieres, many with entire teams in attendance, and films from over 30 countries. With film curator Bina Paul leading the programming, one of this edition's special features will be the 'Himalayan Film Fellows Programme', a programme to teach young filmmakers technical skills, along with more community outreach.

But 'big' is not the aim. "For this edition, and the future, we will be doing more in terms of supporting independent filmmakers. At the same time, ensuring that the festival remains an intimate space," says Sarin. Looking back, Sonam says, "Honestly, we underestimated the amount of work. Had we known better, we might have chickened out. Thankfully, local support and filmmaker friends never let go of our hands." ■

—Sukant Deepak

The festival will take place from ***Oct. 29-Nov. 1*** *at Tibetan Children's Village, Upper Dharamshala*